



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Thomas MacLaren School
School Website: <https://www.maclarenschool.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Thomas MacLaren School (Colorado Springs, CO 80915) presents a coherent classical-education orientation expressed through a K–12 liberal-arts framing, a heavy emphasis on Great Books and Great Conversation, Socratic pedagogy, and a shared, sequenced curriculum with limited tracking. Public-facing materials consistently foreground the liberal-arts ethos, memory-work and recitation in pedagogy, and a culture of lifelong learning and human formation. While the school exhibits many elements aligned with classical education, there are modern notes (e.g., Core Knowledge references, mixed curricular signals around history-focused vs. humanities-focused framing) that introduce nuance and prevent a unilateral determination of being fully classical in every dimension. Overall, the school leans CLASSICAL, with some notable areas that could be strengthened to achieve a more consistently classical profile across all six categories.

Key signals supporting CLASSICAL orientation

- Explicit emphasis on Socratic seminars, the Great Conversation, and a liberal-arts education across K–12, including a common, sequenced curriculum (no tracking) and a clear focus on memory work, recitation, and the cultivation of virtue and wisdom through humane letters and philosophy-oriented study. These features appear repeatedly in the school's public materials.
- Strong same-track, curricular coherence and a litany of Great Books/primary-text engagement (Humane Letters, Western canon, Greek/Hebrew/scriptural readings, etc.), with statements about forming characters and developing a “great conversation” across grades.
- Pedagogy that foregrounds citizenship of mind through seminars, memory, recitation, and rhetoric opportunities, alongside a philosophy of learning as a lifelong, contemplative pursuit.

What would move the needle

- If the aggregate assessment were to tilt toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, concrete steps would include:
- More explicit articulation of the Trivium and Quadrivium as the structural backbone of the curriculum (grammar/logic/rhetoric and mathematics/geometry/music/astronomy) in public messaging.
- Clearer alignment of all curricular strands with the Great Books framework (versus the Core Knowledge reference) to minimize potential signaling of non-classical curricular priorities.
- Strengthened, explicit language around the role of parents as co-educators in the classical formation process.

ABSTRACT

: The school demonstrates a robust classical orientation through Great Books/Great Conversation, Socratic pedagogy, and a shared liberal-arts curriculum, with ongoing formation of virtue and wisdom as core aims. There are nuanced signals (e.g., Core Knowledge references) that introduce non-classical threads; nevertheless, the dominant elements align with classical education.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school emphasizes truth, beauty, and goodness as core ideals in its mission, framing education around formation and the realization of human excellence rather than purely utilitarian aims. For example, the public materials highlight a vision of knowing truth and creating beauty as central aims.
- The broader liberal-arts framing and the focus on formation, virtue, and the pursuit of the true, good, and beautiful appear as recurring themes in program descriptions (e.g., humane letters, Great Books, and seminar pedagogy).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, formation, liberal education, great conversation, wonder, transcendental aims.
- Negative keywords: theology, liturgy, liturgical practices (not explicitly evidenced in public materials); secular or non-theist signals not prominent in the public descriptions. The absence of explicit theology/liturgy signals lowers the score for a fully grounded metaphysical-theological foundation.
- Why this rating
- The school foregrounds transcendent aims (truth, beauty, goodness) and formation, but does not present a sustained explicit theological or liturgical program in its public-facing materials. This yields a CLASSICAL signal tempered by missing explicit theological/metaphysical commitments. The presence of moral-realism and virtue-oriented language supports a strong classical orientation, yet the lack of explicit theology/doxology-laden practices places it in the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL range rather than Fully CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The mission centers on forming virtuous and wise human beings rather than preparing for specific employment outcomes; the school emphasizes formation and the pursuit of true, good, and beautiful as telos. The Great Conversation and liberal-arts formation are presented as central purposes.
- Text and materials describe education as formation, not information, and emphasize humane-letters-style education and confidence in the humanistic telos of education.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: formation, liberal education, telos, scholé/contemplation, great conversation, human excellence, moral imagination.
- Negative keywords: references to preparation for college/career appear only as contextual possibilities, not as primary goals; thus, there is minimal signaling of workforce-prep emphasis.
- Why this rating
- The public materials portray a formation-focused aim consistent with classical education, privileging virtue and wisdom and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty. The absence of a dominant workforce-prep framing strengthens the CLASSICAL rating.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- Curriculum is described as liberal-arts oriented with a sequenced, content-rich approach, emphasizing a common K–12 experience, memory-work, and exposure to classical literature and Great Books through Humane Letters and Great Conversation materials. There is explicit emphasis on a common, sequenced curriculum and intellectual tradition, with references to original texts and classical literature.
- A notable element is the Core Knowledge Sequence referenced in MacLaren materials, along with a strong emphasis on humanities, the arts, and a liberal-arts curriculum. The presence of Core Knowledge introduces a modern curricular signal that is not a canonical feature of classical education.
- Additional materials describe Humane Letters as a driving curricular core, with ninth- through twelfth-grade seminars that integrate literature, history, and philosophy into a unified humanities experience.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: liberal arts, Great Books, Great Conversation, primary sources/original texts, humanities, Humane Letters, memory work, recitation, Socratic dialogue, seminar, rhetoric, unity of knowledge.
- Negative keywords present: Core Knowledge (a signaling that is not strictly aligned with classical pedagogy), project-based learning (not prominently featured, but present as a potential alternative signaling). Core Knowledge and any heavy project-based framing would be viewed as a non-classical signal in some classical lexicons.
- Why this rating
- The curriculum is firmly rooted in liberal-arts traditions with Great Books, original texts, and integrated humanities, yielding a CLASSICAL orientation. The presence of Core Knowledge introduces a robust non-classical element in some strands, which justifies a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation rather than a Fully Classical one.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Pedagogical practices include Socratic seminars, inquiry-driven discussion, memorization, recitation, and singing/narration as memory work, along with contemplative and memory-focused rhythms (scholé). The upper-school emphasis on rhetoric and public speaking is also described. These elements align closely with classical pedagogy.
- There is clear articulation of lower-school activities emphasizing memorization through singing and chant, with upper-school seminars and rhetoric training, including opportunities to present and argue.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: Socratic seminars, narration, recitation, chanting, singing to memorize, scholé, seminar, rhetoric, debates, public speaking, memory-work.
- Negative keywords: experiential/project-based-only approaches are not prominent; if present, they appear only as a caution in classical-lexicon terms. The dominant signals are classical.
- Why this rating
- The pedagogy is richly classical: Socratic dialogue, memory-rich activities, and rhetoric training are central features. The school also foregrounds contemplative/restful learning as part of the educational mix, aligning with scholé pedagogy rather than a purely progressive approach. This justifies CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- Faculty development is a visible priority with faculty seminars described as central to the school's living-curriculum approach; teachers are portrayed as mentors and living exemplars in a collegial culture.
- Documents describe a portrait of what a teacher should be and a student should be, along with a "faculty as living curriculum" notion, indicating an intentional, virtue-centered faculty culture.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: tutors/mentors/masters, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, collegial culture, faculty development, seminars, character formation.
- Negative keywords: none prominent in publicly available materials; no signals that contradict classical-faculty expectations.
- Why this rating
- The faculty construct is strongly aligned with classical expectations (model teachers, living curriculum, mentors, and professional development centered on classical pedagogy). This warrants CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The school signals openness to families and community engagement through public information nights and parent-oriented communications typical of a charter public school; the culture emphasizes a partnership with families as part of the learning environment. However, explicit language describing parents as co-teachers or structured parent-formation programs is not as prominent as in some classical programs.
- The public materials emphasize a "great conversation" culture and community-building aspects (e.g., humane letters, families attending assemblies, etc.), which align with classical-community ideals but without robust explicit parent-formation programming described online.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, broad community engagement, public information nights, family involvement in a shared learning culture.
- Negative keywords present: explicit, structured parent-formation programs, co-teaching commitments, or frequent family-liturgic-style activities are not clearly documented in public materials; the signaling is milder than in some classical-community models.
- Why this rating
- The school presents foundational elements of parental involvement and community engagement consistent with classical aims, but the publicly documented signals for explicit parent-formation/co-teaching roles are less prominent than in idealized classical-community models. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal rather than a fully Classical one.

What Would Move the Needle

- If the school were aiming to move from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL in all six categories, concrete steps could include:
- Explicitly codifying and publicly communicating the Trivium/Quadrivium framework as the curricular backbone (grammar/logic/rhetoric and mathematics/music/astronomy as core strands) and showing how all grades cycle through these components.
- Deepening the "Great Books/Great Conversation" framing in official curriculum documents (beyond humane-letters) to showcase a sustained, canonical-text approach across grade bands.

- Strengthening theology/metaphysical signaling (where appropriate in their charter context) through explicit references to transcendentals and a theologically informed, contemplative classroom ethos, while maintaining a public, non-denominational profile.
- Expanding explicit parent-formation and co-teaching programs (parent seminars, reading groups, family liturgy resources) to strengthen the Parents & Community category.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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